



Birth of the Detective, Birth of a Genre

A Network-Based Approach to the Emergence of the Detective Novel

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Hypothesis: the birth of the genre, read structurally = an investigator who increasingly occupies a position of **structural centrality** in character networks.

Detective Detector
(Barré et al. 2025)

- Detectivehood as a **character-level property** (CamemBERT + SVM, b.acc. 0.923), not a pre-given genre label.

From detective detection to character networks

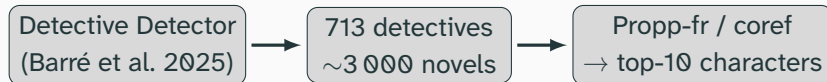
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713 detectives
~3 000 novels

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- Edges = **sentence-window co-presence**, weights accumulate across the narrative.
- Repeated co-presence as a robust proxy for **narrative coupling** at scale (coreference noise mitigated by the top- N restriction — Amalvy et al. 2025).

Quantifying centrality: PageRank

$$PR(i) = \frac{1-d}{|V|} + d \sum_{j \in V} PR(j) \frac{w_{ji}}{\sum_k w_{jk}}, \quad d = 0.85$$

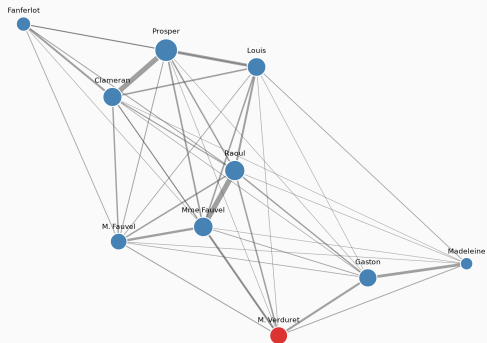
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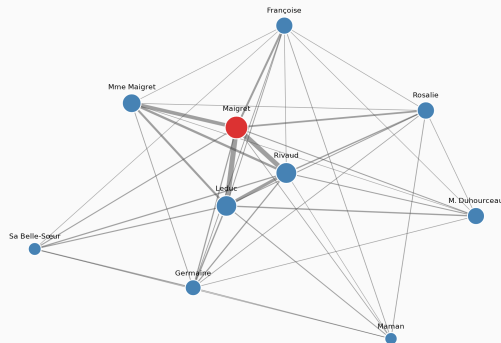
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- Per novel, two comparable quantities:
 PR of the **main character** ($\arg \max_v PR(v)$) vs. PR of the **main detective**.

Relay vs. center: two canonical cases

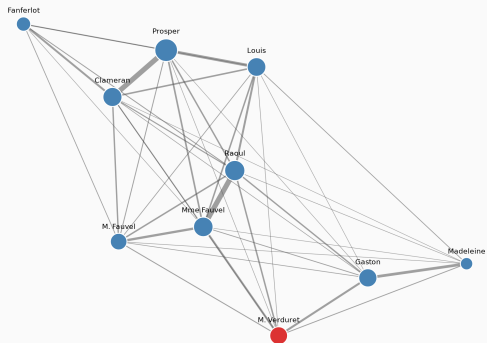


(a) Gaboriau, *Dossier 113* (1867):
Verduret (Lecoq), $PR = 0.079$ — a **relay**

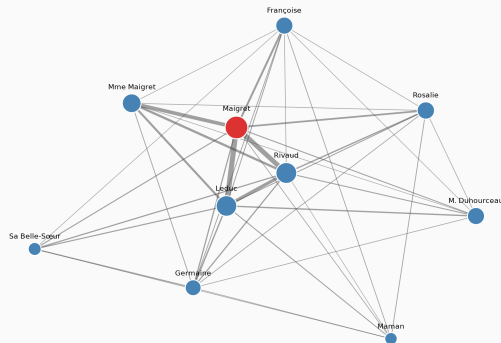


(b) Simenon, *Le fou de Bergerac* (1932):
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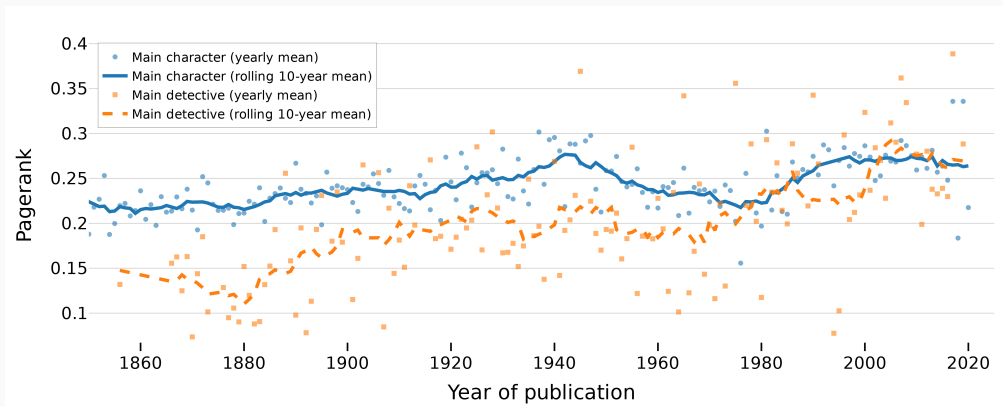


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Detective centrality over time (1850–2020)



Points: yearly means | Lines: 10-year rolling means over yearly means

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- **1970–2020 Final convergence**

Late 1970s–1990s: brief *divergence* = the **néo-polar** (Manchette, Daeninckx) displaces the professional investigator.

~2000→: convergence (Vargas, Lemaitre, Thilliez) — the detective now *is* the main character.

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Contribution: genre emergence operationalized as the stabilization of **formal operators** — here, character architecture — combining archetype detection × network centrality, at scale *and* with access to individual networks for close reading.

Thank you!

Code & data

github.com/lattice-8094/DETECTIVES

Contact

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Appendix: detector performance

Model	B.Acc.	F1 (Det.)
BoW + SVM	0.895	0.84
CamemBERT + SVM	0.923	0.887
LOGO (Author)	0.908	0.873
LOGO (10 yrs)	0.915	0.879
LOGO (50 yrs)	0.892	0.858

Table 1: Evaluation set: detective $n = 185$, non-detective $n = 419$.

Detective class: precision 0.866 / recall 0.908 / F1 0.887.

Appendix: methodological caveats

- **Coreference noise:** upstream NLP errors affect network topology (Amalvy et al. 2025); top- N restriction focuses on entities with stable coreference chains.
- **Co-occurrence $\neq$ interaction:** sentence-window co-presence as a proxy for narrative coupling, not dialogue or “true” social ties.
- **Late-period pattern:** may partly reflect corpus composition (novels per year, uneven digitization) $\rightarrow$ yearly sample sizes and robustness checks in the full version.
- **Undirected graphs:** standard PageRank on symmetric weighted adjacency (reciprocal edges of identical weight).

Appendix: why centrality? Vareille's two temporalities

The detective novel = “the interweaving of one temporal series leading to the discovery of the criminal (the investigation) with another, which moves backward in time and narrates the genesis of the crime” (Vareille 1986, 1989).

This interlocking is only possible if **one character — the detective — occupies the position of mediator** between these two temporalities: collecting clues in the present to reconstruct the criminal past.